The CareLeaders Learning

Course brochure

Understanding care

The Journey Through Care

One child's story, the whole care journey.

Our flagship course follows Sam from before he came into care to the day he left. Six sessions of 60 minutes, each pairing his story with the theory behind it, so school staff, social care teams and carers understand what life is like for children in care and what to do differently.



Length
Six sessions over six weeks

How
Live online or face to face

Group
Whole-service cohorts: Kent ran three of 145 to 174 staff

For
Schools and more

The problem it solves

Staff see the behaviour, the missed meeting and the file, but not the life behind them. That gap shows up in escalations, in records that label, and in schools and social care misreading each other while the child falls between them.

Helps with

- Trauma-informed practice
- School attendance and attainment
- Stability and matching



What changes

What is different after the course.

For your staff

- Read behaviour as communication and respond to it, not treat it as defiance
- Change the language they use about children in meetings and in records
- Picture the care journey from the child's side when planning support
- Work across school and social care, knowing how the other side works

For children

- Adults who ask what happened before reacting to what they did
- Meetings and records that describe them fairly, without labels
- School and social care staff who understand each other's world
- More understanding at the hard points: entering care, moving and leaving

What they learn

The knowledge and the tools.

- What happens to a child before, during and after care, from the child's side
- Child development, adverse childhood experiences, attachment, trauma and loss
- How to read behaviour as communication and respond to it
- The language and recording that shape a child's life, and how to get them right
- What school, social care and leaving care look like to the child, and how to work across them

Who it is for

- Teachers, teaching assistants and designated teachers
- Social workers, personal advisers and early help staff
- Foster carers and residential staff
- New starters in children's services, and anyone who wants to understand the journey through care

Session by session

How the course runs.

 Story  Theory  Action

1 Before care

Sam's story starts before birth. What happens before a child comes into care, and what it does to a developing brain and body: child development, adverse childhood experiences and parenting styles.

You leave with A handout on ACEs and parenting styles, and a reflection task

2 Entering care

The real reasons children come into care, the types of care (foster, residential and kinship), and what the first days, weeks and a placement move feel like from the child's side.

You leave with A handout on routes into care and the types of care

3 Attachment, trauma and loss

Attachment theory, trauma and loss, told through what Sam did and didn't do with the adults around him. Why a child who has lost everyone finds it hard to trust.

You leave with A handout on attachment styles and relationship-focused practice

4 Behaviour as communication

Emotional regulation, the window of tolerance, and what behaviour is telling you when a child can't say it. Then what to do in the moment.

You leave with A way to read the message in behaviour and respond in the moment

5 Language and recording

Someone is going to read this. The words adults use about children in care, in meetings and in records, and what it is like to read your own file years later.

You leave with A check for your own language, with writing to the child in mind

6 School, social care and leaving care

Education for children in care, where school and social care clash, and what leaving care really means, including what happens at 18.

You leave with A plan for working across school and social care for one child

Choose how you run it

Formats.

Live online

Live sessions online with a facilitator, so teams across a large area can join without travelling.

Length	Six sessions of 60 minutes, usually one a week after school
Group	Your cohort, up to whole-service cohorts
You provide	Teams or Zoom, cameras on, a quiet space

Face to face

We come to you: development days, twilights and team days, in your building or a venue you choose.

Length	Six twilight sessions, or compressed into a development day
Group	A whole staff team
You provide	A room, a screen and the time protected

Included: Session handouts, a reflection task between sessions, and the slides to keep

Delivered Six twilight sessions for three Virtual School Kent cohorts, around 490 staff. 124 of 125 said the first session met its objectives.

Can school staff and social care staff join the same cohort?

Yes. It was built for both, and session 6 is about where school and social care meet. Kent's cohorts brought teachers, school staff, college staff and social care staff together.

What do staff do between sessions?

A short reflection task. We also ask each person to bring a real child, anonymised, to think about across the six sessions, so the theory lands on someone they know.

How long is each session?

60 minutes. Six sessions make the full course, usually one a week.

Is it online or in person?

Both. Live online is the most common. Face to face works as twilight sessions or a development day.

Can we have the recordings?

Yes. We record the series for your organisation and license it for a year, on your platform or ours.

Who delivers it?

Facilitators with lived experience of care and professional experience of the schools and social work teams around it. Sam's story is told from lived experience.

How many people can join?

Whole-service cohorts work. Kent ran three cohorts of 145 to 174 staff. Licensed recordings have no limit.

Is it CPD certified?

Participants who complete the course receive a certificate of completion from us for CPD purposes.



Luke Rodgers BEM
Founder and CEO, The Care Leaders

Who designs and delivers it

From care leaver to care leader.

Luke went into care at 10. At 15 he was living in a bed and breakfast, and at 18 in a caravan. He gave his first keynote at 19, and has spent his career since inside children's services as a consultant, trainer, speaker and national engagement lead.

He set up The Care Leaders to go from care leaver to care leader, and to help others make the same move. He led the national engagement on England's new fostering standards, was a Knowledge Equity Fellow at Saïd Business School, University of Oxford, and was awarded the British Empire Medal in 2018.

Every course is designed by Luke and follows the same Story, Theory, Action approach. It is delivered by people with lived experience of care and professional experience of children's services.

- **Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award**
  iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026
- **British Empire Medal**
  2018, for commitment to children and families
- **Knowledge Equity Fellow**
  Saïd Business School, University of Oxford
- **45+ keynotes since 2024**
  From team days to national conferences

The CareLeaders Learning

Getting started

Bring The Journey Through Care to your team.

1 **Get in touch**
Tell us who it is for and roughly how many people.

2 **Have a call**
We talk through your service, your people and your dates.

3 **Get a clear quote**
We quote per cohort, based on numbers, format and how much tailoring you want.

4 **We run it**
Shaped around your service, your procedures and the children you work with.

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Often booked with

Understanding care
Behind the Behaviour
Reading behaviour as communication, and responding without losing the relationship.

Schools
Two Timetables: When School Meets Social Care
Teachers and social workers learning each other's worlds, so children stop falling between them.

Understanding care
Trauma, Attachment and Transitions
What moving does to a child, and what the adults around them can do about it.

iese Awards GOLD Winner 2026 The Public Sector Transformation Awards

Children & Young People Now Awards 2023 Winner

Gold, Dual Perspective Leadership Award, iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026.
Children & Young People Now Workforce Development Award 2023.